
POLISH EARLY MUSIC 4

PIOTR Z GRUDZIĄDZA

1392 – after 1452

Plaude euge theotocos



for three voices

CRITICAL EDITION

from Leipzig, Universitätsbibliothek, Ms 1236, f. 139v

edited by Mikołaj Derduń

First edition · 2026

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POLISH EARLY MUSIC 4. Piotr z Grudziądza, *Plaude euge theotocos*. First edition, 2026. Edited by Mikołaj Derduń.

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Source files, corrections and later editions: <https://github.com/mderdun/pol-ren/editions/plaude-euge>.

Set in Junicode; music engraved with LilyPond and Gregorio.

THE SOURCE

PLAUDE EUGE THEOTOCOS survives in a single manuscript, Leipzig, Universitätsbibliothek, Ms 1236, f. 139v. The book is a paper miscellany of 579 leaves (21.5 × 14 cm), mostly grammar, theology and philosophy, copied in 1447 and 1449; one colophon places its copying in Parchim, in Mecklenburg. It belonged to Johannes Klein of Löbau (Lubawa, in the Chełmno land, not far from Grudziądz), who matriculated at Leipzig in 1447, later taught in the arts faculty, and left his books to the university's Small Princes' College when he died in 1490.

Music fills only a few leaves. Two more pieces by Piotr come before this one, *Presulem ephebeatum* on ff. 79v–80v and the motet *Pax eterna / Jacob scalam / Terribilis est locus iste* on the leaves just before this one, and an anonymous *Veni dulcis consolator* follows on the lower half of f. 139v. A treatise on music begins on f. 140r. Of the seventeen sources of Piotr's music copied in his lifetime, seven come from universities, two of them from Leipzig. Klein's book is a student's copy of the kind that carried his songs from Kraków across central Europe. It is also an early copy, made in Piotr's lifetime. Many of his songs reached later singers through Bohemian copies, and Paweł Gancarczyk has shown how those copies changed them. They gave the songs new texts, altered rhythms at cadences, and dropped or rewrote the middle voice. No other copy of *Plaude* survives to compare, but a copy this early has had less time to drift from what Piotr wrote.

The scribe wrote the three voices one after another, each in its own block, and labelled the upper two Discantus and Medius in the margin; the lowest voice has the cue 'Tenor ymni Plaude' ('Tenor of the hymn *Plaude*'; the reading of *ymni* is uncertain). The notation is void mensural notation in a fast cursive hand. The Discantus and Medius are written in semibreves and minims, with their text copied as a continuous line under the notes rather than set note by note. The Tenor is written almost entirely in ligatures and carries no text beyond its cues: the incipit, 'Te laudantes inspicie' ('look upon those who praise you') where the second part begins, and '2a fi[n]alis' ('second final') and '2a finale' ('second ending') over the second endings. No voice has a clef, a mensuration sign or an accidental. Below the word Discantus is a small sign shaped like a b. The scribe ruled five-line staves by hand, unevenly, and many notes sit loosely on them. The ends of the Discantus and Medius staves run into the gutter, and the final notes of the Discantus in both second endings cannot be seen.

THE COMPOSER

Piotr z Grudziądza, known in Latin as Petrus Wilhelmi de Grudencz, was born in 1392 in Grudziądz (Graudenz), then in the Prussian state of the Teutonic Order, to a family of knightly rank. He matriculated at the University of Kraków in 1418, became bachelor of arts in 1425 and master in 1430. The later documents place him at the court of Frederick III. In 1442, at Frankfurt am Main, the royal chancery issued him a letter of familiarity and safe conduct. In 1448 the bishop of Wrocław recommended him, without success, for a canonry at Frombork. In 1452 a petition to the papal curia calls him chaplain to the Emperor; he was probably in Rome for Frederick's coronation. Nothing is known of him after that year. The death date of about 1480 found in older literature rests on a supposed stay in Silesia that no document confirms. He was a chaplain, not a member of the musical chapel, and he appears to have had no musical duties.

His songs, or *cantiones*, are short Latin pieces for two or three voices, simple in structure and regular in rhythm. Černý showed that they grow out of the Central European song repertory of around 1400, to which Piotr added newer harmonic habits. They were sung mainly in university circles, at Kraków, Vienna and Leipzig, and in the later fifteenth century by the literary brotherhoods of the Bohemian Utraquist churches. About forty works are attributed to him, in more than fifty sources copied between about 1420 and 1726, from Trent to Lwów and from Frankfurt to Masovia; nearly half of the sources are Bohemian. Thirty-three works carry his signature as an acrostic, and this piece is one of them. The manuscript names no composer, but the initials of the opening words spell PETRVS: *Plaude Euge Theotocos Regina Virginum Salus*. Jaromír Černý included the piece in his edition of the complete works (1993).

THE POEM

Piotr wrote the texts of his songs himself; the acrostic makes that certain here, since the words had to be found to fit the letters. The poem is a single stanza of eight short lines in two halves. The first half greets the Virgin, the second asks her for mercy on those who sing. Each half is sung twice, with a different musical ending the second time. The source spells *confidencium* and *misericordie*, and this edition keeps those spellings.

Theotocos is the Greek *Theotokos*, ‘God-bearer’, the title for Mary confirmed at the Council of Ephesus in 431. It belongs to the Byzantine liturgy, but it was never only an Eastern word. Latin writers used it from the Nestorian controversy onwards (John Cassian glosses it ‘theotocos, id est dei mater’, ‘theotocos, that is, mother of God’), the schools met it in the Latin John of Damascus, and Western liturgical poetry used it freely: the office antiphon *Ave o theotokos virgo Maria* (‘Hail, O God-bearer, Virgin Mary’), sequences such as *Ave salutata ab angelo*, which has ‘Ave, o theotocos’ (‘Hail, O God-bearer’), and a hymn in fifteenth-century breviaries that prays ‘Succurre, o Theotocos’ (‘Help, O God-bearer’). In Piotr’s poetry it is one of many Greek borrowings, alongside *ephebeatum* and *pneuma eucaristiarum*, which show off the learning of a Kraków master. I suspect it also solved a practical problem. The acrostic needs a word beginning with T, and *Dei genitrix* (‘mother of God’) would not serve.

The rest of the language is common Marian stock. *Plaude* and *euge* together (‘rejoice’, ‘well done!’) appear in Jan of Jenštejn’s Visitation sequence *Ave verbi Dei parens*, copied in some forty Bohemian sources. *Euge* comes from the Vulgate (‘Euge, serve bone’, ‘Well done, good servant’, Matthew 25:21); here it supplies the E. *Regina virginum* is the antiphon’s ‘Haec est regina virginum’ (‘This is the queen of virgins’), and rhymed Marian prayers of the period call her the hope ‘in te confidentium’ (‘of those who trust in you’). The closing lines echo the *Salve Regina*: ‘illos tuos misericordes oculos ad nos converte’ (‘turn those merciful eyes of yours towards us’). The title of the oldest Polish hymn, *Bogurodzica*, is the same word. It means ‘God-bearer’ and is a calque of *Theotokos*.

The Tenor’s cue calls the piece a *hymnus*. In the medieval sense that means any song of praise to God or the saints (Isidore: ‘hymnus est canticum laudantium’, ‘a hymn is a song of those who praise’), which the second half’s *Te laudantes* (‘those praising you’) makes literal. Nothing ties it to a feast or an office. It is a devotional song of the kind sung by students, clerics and townspeople in central Europe, in school, at home or in church.

PITCH

Because the source has no clefs, every pitch in a modern score of this piece is a reconstruction, and so is the vertical relation of the voices. This edition keeps Monique Rio’s reading, a final on D with B♭. I tested it against the counterpoint. Read this way, the three voices form consonances on almost every semibreve, while moving any one voice up or down by a step produces dissonance throughout. The flat has to apply to all three voices. With a flat in the Discantus alone, the lower voices form tritones on nearly every b. The key signature here is therefore editorial, like the clefs, and it is applied to the whole score. The source has no accidentals either. The editorial ones follow two rules of the period: voices should not sound a tritone against each other (*mi contra fa*), and a sixth that widens to an octave at a cadence should be major. Where the two pull against each other, or against the melodic rule *una nota super la* (‘one note above la’), the critical notes explain the choice. The recording by Schola Gregoriana Pragensis decides differently in three places, and those are noted too.

At this pitch the Discantus lies between c’ and bb’, the Medius between c and c’, and the Tenor between G and g. The piece suits alto, tenor and bass, and there is no need to transpose it.

THE TENOR: SUNG OR PLAYED?

Both recordings of the piece treat the Tenor as something other than a sung text. La Morra (2016) gives it to a fiddle; in the recording by Schola Gregoriana Pragensis (2005) a bass hums it. The name of the voice does not settle whether that is right. In the fifteenth century *tenor* named a function, the voice on which the others were built, and not a range; in three-voice songs of this period the lowest voice is regularly the Tenor. The other two names are local. Central European treatises of Piotr's time, the Mazovian *Circa artem* and Paulus Paulirinus, describe pieces in which the *discantus* and *medium* have text while the tenor has none and moves in longer values. That is exactly the layout of this page. Nor can its low range be pressed, since without clefs the absolute pitch is an editor's choice. All that is certain is that it lies about an octave below the *Discantus*.

The notation is better evidence. The Tenor has no text, and it is written almost entirely in ligatures, each of which carries a single syllable. The scribe did not expect anyone to sing the words to it syllable by syllable. Its long values fit an instrument well, and instruments were at hand: Paulus Paulirinus, writing in Prague about 1460, describes the fiddle, lute, clavichord and organ. Reinhard Strohm notes that the three-part songs of the Glogau songbook could be played on three string instruments, sung, or mixed.

The case for voices is just as strong. Since the work of Christopher Page and David Fallows in the late 1970s and early 1980s, many scholars have held that much of this repertory was sung throughout. Page argues that vocalisation, singing a textless line without words, was a standard resource of trained singers, all the more because instruments other than the organ were normally kept out of church. He also observes that in sources of the early fifteenth century lower voices increasingly carry partial text, generally at moments of imitation or declamation. This Tenor carries text cues for both halves and for the endings, as if its reader was meant to follow the words.

Both ways of performing it have history behind them, and so does a texted tenor. Gancarczyk shows that a copyist of the anonymous Central European motet *Ave coronata* divided the long notes of its textless tenor into short values so that it could sing the words of the *discantus*, blurring the original design. Copyists of Piotr's own songs adjusted the tenor's rhythm at section endings, lengthening a note or adding a minim. This edition prints a texted Tenor as an option for an all-vocal performance. It follows Page's observation rather than the *Ave coronata* copyist, so the Tenor takes text mainly where the upper voices declaim together.

The Tenor's text is printed in italics because none of it is in the source. The Tenor keeps its long notes so that it can hold a sustained line under the declaiming upper voices, and it sings only as much of the text as fits: 'Plaude theotocos / regina virginum / salus confidencium' ('Rejoice, Mother of God, queen of virgins, salvation of those who trust'), and 'Te laudantes inspice / nec despice / sed hos oculis respice' ('Look upon those who praise you, do not despise them, but look on them with your eyes'). The words it leaves out are sung by the upper voices, and what it sings still makes sense on its own. Notes are divided only in the endings, and dashed ties mark the divisions. The two endings of the first part differ. The first time, the Tenor begins the repeated *confidencium* half a bar early, with *con-fi* in two minims, and puts its stress, *-den-*, on the downbeat of bar 15 while the upper voices sing *con-*. The second time, it holds its breve and then takes the rhythm and words of the upper voices, four minims into the final breve. In the first ending of the second part the breve on d is halved to carry *respice*. The Tenor can equally be vocalised or played from this score.

SOURCES

MS

Leipzig, Universitätsbibliothek, Ms 1236, f. 139v. Digital images: <https://nbn-resolving.org/urn:nbn:de:bsz:15-0028-574721> (Public Domain Mark). *Base text*.

Edition and recording collated:

- Ⓡ Monique Rio (ed.), *Plaude euge theotocos* (St Cecilia Press and CPDL, 2016), the one widely used today.
- Ⓟ Schola Gregoriana Pragensis, *Maiestas Dei* (Supraphon SU 3807-2, 2005), cited for its accidentals and underlay as heard.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Pitch and clefs. The pitch is that described above, written in modern treble, octave-treble and bass clefs. The key signature is editorial.

Note values and barring. The note values are those of the source (semibreve = whole note). Lines between the staves mark every breve, and the staves themselves are left without barlines, so notes run across them as they do in the source. Bar numbers count breves and include both endings. The source has no mensuration sign. The music moves in imperfect tempus and minor prolation throughout.

Repeats. The source writes each half once, followed by its first ending, and then the second ending after a double stroke marked '2a' ('second'). The score uses repeat signs and numbered endings for this. In the first part the bar before the endings (bar 14) is printed in both endings, so that the Tenor can take it differently each time; the upper voices are the same in both. In the source the endings begin one bar later.

Accidentals. The source has none. Editorial accidentals stand above the note they affect, in small type, and apply to that note only. There are four: naturals in bars 20 and 30, and two sharps in the final cadence, bar 35. The critical notes give the reasons, and note where Ⓡ and Ⓟ differ.

Supplied notes. Notes hidden in the gutter of the manuscript are supplied in square brackets. These are the last notes of the Discantus in the two second endings, each printed as a long like the final notes of the other voices (see Final notes).

Text. Spelling follows the source; capitals and punctuation are editorial. The source does not align syllables with notes in any voice, so the underlay throughout is editorial. It follows the phrase structure. Each line of the poem ends at a cadence, with its last syllable on the arrival note: in the second part, *inspice* at the cadence on A (bar 24), *despice* on G (bar 27) and *oculis* on C (bar 31), the first note of each ending. Stressed syllables fall on the beat and usually on longer notes (*laudantes, inspice, miseros, despice, misericordie, oculis, respice*). A repeated note takes a new syllable. Melismas fall on the stressed or the penultimate syllable before a cadence. Where the upper voices move together, they declaim together. I took these rules from sixteenth-century theorists, writing a century after this music, and applied them only where they make musical sense. The Tenor's text is wholly editorial, printed in italics, and shortened so that it keeps its long notes (see above).

Final notes. The source writes the last note of each ending as a long in the Tenor, and in the Medius at the end of each second ending. They are printed as longs, each filling its bar, and are held until all voices have finished. The Discantus's last note in each second ending, hidden in the gutter and supplied in brackets, is printed as a long in the same way, so that all three voices end together on longs. No fermata is added.



TEXT AND TRANSLATION

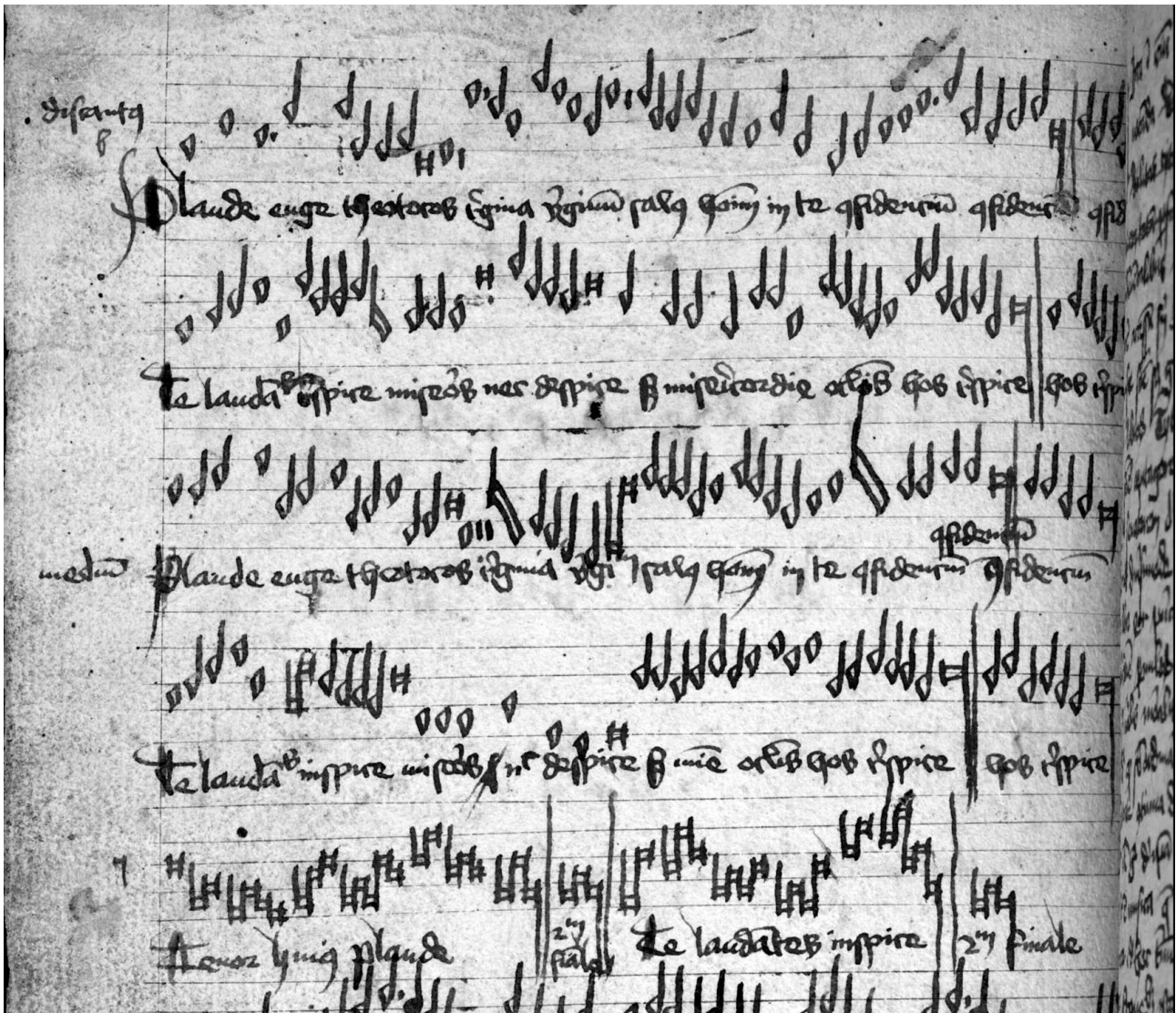
Plaude, euge, theotocos,
regina virginum,
salus hominum
in te confidencium.

Te laudantes inspice,
miseros nec despice,
sed misericordie
oculis hos respice.

Rejoice, well done, Mother of God,
queen of virgins,
salvation of all
who trust in you.

Look upon those who praise you,
do not despise the wretched,
but look on them
with the eyes of mercy.

FACSIMILE



Leipzig, Universitätsbibliothek, Ms 1236, f. 139v (upper part). Discantus (staves 1–2), Medius (staves 3–4), Tenor (stave 5). Leipzig University Library, Public Domain Mark.

Plaude euge theotocos

PIOTR Z GRUDZIĄDZA

DISCANTUS

MEDIUS

TENOR

Plau - de eu - ge the - o - to - cos

Plau - de eu - ge the - o - to - cos

Plau - de the - o - to - cos

D.

M.

T.

re - gi - na vir - gi - num

re - gi - na vir - gi - num

re - gi - na vir - gi - num

D.

M.

T.

sa - lus ho - mi - num in te con - fi - den - ci -

sa - lus ho - mi - num in te con - fi - den - ci -

sa - - - lus con - fi - den - ci -

D.

M.

T.

1. um con - fi - den - ci - um

2. um con - fi - den - ci - um

um con - fi - den - ci - um

um con - fi - den - ci - um

um con - fi - den - ci - um

um con - fi - den - ci - um

20

D. Te lau - dan - tes in - spi - ce mi - se - ros

M. Te lau - dan - tes in - spi - ce

T. Te lau - dan - tes in - spi - ce

25

D. nec de - spi - ce

M. mi - se - ros nec de - spi - ce

T. nec de - spi - ce

28

D. sed mi - se - ri - cor - di - e o - cu -

M. sed mi - se - ri - cor - di - e o - cu -

T. sed hos o - cu -

31

1. lis hos re - spi - ce

2. lis hos re - spi - ce

M. lis hos re - spi - ce

T. lis re - spi - ce



CRITICAL NOTES

Locations are given as bar, voice and note number, counting rests. D = Discantus, M = Medius, T = Tenor. (R) reduces the note values by four, bars in 2/4 with two bars of 3/4 (bars 6–8 here, which need no change of metre in breve barring), and gives the Tenor no text.

BAR	VOICE	NOTE
1	M 3	(MS) b, no accidental. Printed as bb by the signature, a fifth below the D f'. (R) and (P) sing ḅ, which makes the rise a–b–c' smoother but forms a tritone with the D f'. Compare 20 M 3.
2	D 2	The minim stands almost as high as the g' that follows it (3 D 1). Read as f', as in (R).
2	T 2	(MS) b, no accidental; bb by the signature, as in (R) and (P). The note sounds against the D e' held from the previous beat, so either reading is dissonant. With bb it forms a tritone, with ḅ a fourth above the lowest voice. The Tenor rises from a to b and falls to g, and the rule <i>una nota super la semper est canendum fa</i> (a single note above la is sung as fa) favours the flat.
6–10	M	Underlay: <i>regina</i> is sung after the rests rather than divided by them, so the e at 6 M 1 continues <i>theotocos</i> ; -num is held over two semibreves and <i>salus</i> follows in bar 10. (P) places the text the same way.
10	D	Text: (MS) <i>salus</i> ; (R) prints <i>sallus</i> .
14–19		(MS) writes bar 14 once, before the repeat; here it is printed in both endings so that the Tenor can vary (see Editorial method). T bars 14–19: the divided notes and the second-ending rhythm are editorial.
15	M 3–4	(MS) b–b, rising, where the second ending has a–a–g–g (18 M 3–4). (P) sings g–g in both endings. Here the Tenor has d, so g would form a fourth above it on the beat (d–g–f'); with bb the sonority is d–bb–f'. In the second ending the Tenor has bb, and g is a sixth above it.
16, 19	T	The last note of each ending is a long in (MS), printed here as a long.
18–19	D	Only the first three notes of this ending are clear in (MS). Note 4 is partly visible and the last note is hidden in the gutter. (R) gives c'. This edition supplies e', printed as a long like the final notes of the Medius and Tenor. The Tenor's bb–a and the Medius's g–a make a cadence on A, and the Discantus then takes d'–e', as it does in the first ending.
19	M 1	(MS) writes a long, placed between f and g. With T bb–a, the cadence requires a (as (R)).
20	M 3	̣ editorial ((R) bb; (P) ḅ). The figure is the same as at 1 M 3, but the counterpoint is not. Here the Discantus rises d'–e'–f'–g' a fifth above the Medius g–a–b–c', so bb would make four parallel fifths in a row; ḅ breaks the chain with a diminished fifth on a passing minim. In bar 1 the Discantus moves differently (f' held over a–bb, then e') and no fifths arise, so the flat stands there.
25	M 1–4	(MS) writes these four notes as semibreves, without stems. As written, the Medius would run two semibreves longer than the other voices; read as minims, as in (R).
29	M 3	This bb forms a fourth with the Tenor's f for a whole semibreve, the only such place in the piece. (MS) and (R) agree; it may be a copying error, but no simple emendation removes it.
30	M 2	̣ editorial, as in (R). With bb the note would form a tritone with the D e'.
31–36		(MS) writes the text of the second part in each upper voice as '... oculis hos respice', then 'hos respice' after the double stroke. The text is not aligned with the notes, so the cue cannot be taken literally; the second ending has too few notes for the Discantus to sing <i>oculis hos respice</i> there. The cadence on C at the start of the endings closes the phrase <i>sed misericordie oculis</i> , so all voices sing -lis on its first note and <i>hos respice</i> after it, in both endings. (R) has the same reading in the second ending.
33, 36	T	The last note is a long in (MS), printed here as a long.

BAR	VOICE	NOTE
35	D 4, M 4	# editorial in both voices ((R) and (P) have neither). In the final cadence the Tenor falls e–d under the Discantus c'–d' and the Medius g–a. The rule that a sixth widening to an octave should be major calls for c#'; with it the Medius g must also be raised, or the upper voices form a tritone (e–g–c#'). Raising both gives the double leading-tone cadence common in the period. Leaving both natural, as (R) and (P) do, is the other consistent reading; c#' with g♯ is not.
36	D	The last note is hidden in the gutter of (MS) and is supplied, printed as a long like the final notes of the Medius and Tenor.

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